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ANI

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, **centre**, Chinese President Xi Jinping, **right**, and Russian President Vladimir Putin share a light moment in Tianjin yesterday.

Xi, Putin train guns on West at regional summit in China

Chinese leader slams ‘bullying behaviour’ from certain countries

TIANJIN, CHINA

Presidents Xi Jinping and Vladimir Putin took turns yesterday to swipe at the West during a gathering of Eurasian leaders for a showpiece summit aimed at putting Beijing front and centre of regional relations.

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), comprising China, India, Russia, Pakistan, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan and Belarus, is touted as a non-Western style of collaboration and seeks to be an alternative to traditional alliances.

Xi told the SCO leaders, including Belarusian president Alexander Lukashenko and India’s

Xi, Putin and Modi were seen on live footage chatting, the three leaders flanked by their translators. Modi and Putin were photographed holding hands.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, that the global international situation was becoming more “chaotic and intertwined”.

The Chinese leader also slammed “bullying behaviour” from certain countries – a veiled reference to the United States. “The security and development tasks facing member states have become even more challenging,” he said in his address in the northern port city of Tianjin. “Looking to the future, with the world undergoing turbulence and transformation, we must continue to follow the

Shanghai spirit ... and better perform the functions of the organisation,” Xi added.

Western provocation

Putin used his speech to defend Russia’s Ukraine offensive, blaming the West for triggering the three-and-a-half year conflict that has killed tens of thousands and devastated much of eastern Ukraine. “This crisis wasn’t triggered by Russia’s attack on Ukraine, but was a result of a coup in Ukraine, which was supported and provoked by the West,” Putin said. “The second reason for the crisis is the West’s constant attempts to drag Ukraine into Nato.”

Earlier, leaders from the ten SCO countries posed for a group photo. Xi, Putin and Modi were seen on live footage chatting, the three leaders flanked by their translators. Modi and Putin were photographed holding hands.

— AFP

SEE ALSO P12

RTA launches new direct Metro route on Red Line

Centreport to Al Fardan service will reduce crowding

DUBAI

BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Senior Assistant Editor

Dubai’s Roads and Transport Authority (RTA) has introduced a new direct route on the Red Line, further strengthening the city’s Metro network and easing peak-hour congestion for thousands of daily commuters.

The newly launched service connects Centreport Station with Al Fardan Exchange Station, providing an additional travel option for passengers during peak morning and evening hours.

It complements the two existing direct routes – Centreport to Expo City Dubai



and Centreport to Life Pharmacy Station – making the Red Line more versatile and responsive to passenger needs. RTA now operates a total of three-routes on the Red Line. The RTA had earlier introduced direct route between Centreport Station and the Expo City Station.

It confirmed that Red Line trains will now alternate between Expo City Dubai and UAE Exchange terminals, while also serving Life Pharmacy Station and Al Fardan Exchange Station directly.

Over 800 dead in Afghanistan earthquake

6.0 QUAKE SHAKES BUILDINGS FROM KABUL TO ISLAMABAD; 2,755 INJURED

JALALABAD, AFGHANISTAN

A massive rescue operation was underway in Afghanistan yesterday, after a strong earthquake and multiple aftershocks flattened homes in a remote, mountainous region, killing more than 800 people, the Taliban authorities said.

A 6.0-magnitude earthquake struck just before midnight, shaking buildings from Kabul to neighbouring Pakistan’s capital, Islamabad.

More than 1.2 million people likely felt strong or very strong shaking, according to the US Geological Survey (USGS).

Near the epicentre in the east of Afghanistan, around 800 people were killed and 2,500 injured in remote Kunar province alone, chief Taliban government spokesman Zabihullah Mujahid said. Another 12 people were killed and 255 injured in neighbouring Nangarhar province, he added.

Many houses destroyed

“Numerous houses were destroyed,” interior ministry spokesman Abdul Mateen Qani told AFP. The majority of Afghans live in low-rise, mud-brick homes that are vulnerable to collapse. Some of the most severely impacted villages in remote Kunar provinces “remain inaccessible due to road blockages”, the UN migration agency warned in a statement to AFP.

UAE’S CONDOLENCES

The UAE has expressed its solidarity with Afghanistan over the earthquake victims.

In a statement, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs (MoFA) conveyed the UAE’s sincere condolences and sympathy to the families of the victims, and to the people of Afghanistan over this tragedy, as well as its wishes for a speedy recovery for the injured.

— WAM

The Taliban authorities and the United Nations mobilised rescue efforts to hard-hit areas. The defence ministry said 40 flight sorties had so far been carried out.

A member of the agricultural department in Kunar’s Nurgal district said people had rushed to clear blocked roads to isolated villages, but that badly affected areas were remote and had limited telecoms networks.

“There is a lot of fear and tension ... Children and women were screaming. We had never experienced anything like this in our lives,” Ijaz Ulhaq Yaad told AFP.

He said that many living in quake-hit villages were among the more than four million Afghans who have returned to the country from Iran and Pakistan in recent years. “They wanted to build their homes here.” — AFP

SEE ALSO P11



Ahmad Al Sayegh new UAE Health Minister

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, has announced the appointment of Ahmad Al Sayegh as Minister of Health.

Al Sayegh has served as Minister of State at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs since September 2018, overseeing economic and trade affairs.

He replaces Abdul Rahman Al Owais, who served as Health Minister for several years, during which the ministry witnessed continuous reforms to develop the federal health system. Al Owais will continue to serve as Minister of State for Federal National Council Affairs.

On his official X account, Shaikh Mohammad wrote: “Brothers and sisters: After the approval of my brother, the President of the UAE, we announce today the appointment of Ahmad Al Sayegh as the Minister of Health in the UAE.”

HEALTH

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NATION

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